

Carnival attracts a global audience

By Kaya Equevilley

The Carnival of Venice has deep roots in Venetian culture and history, dating back to Medieval times around 1094. After the abolition of the carnival when Venice was conquered by Austria, the carnival was recreated in a modern form in 1979. When the carnival started it was a way to transcend hierarchy and economic class barriers. In the beginning, maybe people saw wearing the masks as a way to escape everyday life, without the fear of judgement. Now, the Venice Carnival is a celebration of the history and culture of Venice with people from all over the world. This connection of people creates a relationship amongst the participants.



In San Marco Piazza
costumers walk around and
pose for tourists,
photographers, and locals
from fat Tuesday and Ash
Wednesday. Many of the
people who come to carnival
make their own costumes.



A group of three men from France work with a photographer for the Venice Carnival on Feb 25. William Choux, the costume designer (in blue), has been attending the Venice Carnival since 1985. His first experience with the carnival was with his grandparents, and since then he has been coming back. "It usually takes about a year to make the costume," said Choux.



When the weather is good, costumers meet at 6 a.m. in San Marco's Plaza to pose for photographers on Feb 28. The red joker, Ute Knueppe is from Germany and attends carnival because of the creativity. "There is a community, it's like a big international family. That is why we all still come, it's a family," said Knueppe. After 27 years Knueppe still attends Carnival. She brings between two and five costumes for Carnival depending on if she flies or takes the train to Venice.



Sonja Nenno poses for photographers in San Marco Plaza while her husband Marco watches at sunrise on Feb 28. Marco and Sonja Nenno travel from Germany to experience Carnival. While they have a manager, they also interact with locals and visitors from around the world in the spirit of Carnival. Marco, to the right of Sonja, said he originally came because his wife made it her hobby and creates all of their costumes. It's his fourth time to Venice's carnival.



Sonja Nenno has come to Venice Carnival each year for the past 11 years from Germany. Her love for carnival starts with her love for history and her love to sew. "It is a big community of friends," said Nenno. A local friend she made at a previous Carnival created Sonja's mask. She said that there are many parts that go into planning the costume. "You have to consider hiding all of the ties that hold the mask in, and the weight, the colors, you have to plan," she said.



Posing for photographers outside of the Ducale Palace, Prtty visits Venice for her ninth year during Carnival at sunrise on Feb 28. "Oh! Its magic," said Ptty. Ptty travels from France and stays in Venice for about two weeks each year. It takes her between three and four months to make her costume.



Chantal Frei from Switzerland connects with her team of photographers in her fifth year at the Venice Carnival at sunrise on Feb 28. This is Frei's second year in costume attending the Carnival. "There is a family among people in costume," said Frei.



At the daily morning photo session Laura Ragain from France poses for photographers and tourists for the Venice Carnival. Ragain attends the Carnival each year for five years. Her first experience with Carnival was in 2018 when she came as a tourist. Ragain brings her godson with her to share the experience, tradition, and community of the Carnival now.